

The “Best Offer” Estimation Trap

Why “la meilleure offre du marché” guarantees project failure—and the WBS engineering antidote.

The Name Tricks You

- The term "Best Offer" sounds like excellence and value optimization.
- In software engineering, it is the exact opposite: a highly flawed, high-risk method to be actively avoided.
- It forces a fundamental ethical dilemma: *Should we win contracts by lying about effort?*
- If the answer is no, this method is incompatible with responsible engineering.



What Is the "Best Offer" Method?

The Core Principle

Also known as *la meilleure offre du marché*, its fundamental premise is brutally simple: the project costs whatever the client is ready to pay.

It completely bypasses objective metrics in favor of securing a signature at any cost.

The Pricing Reality

The price is **not** based on specification, design, implementation, testing, or maintenance.

Instead, the price is reverse-engineered to match an arbitrary target budget, a competitor's quote, or what the client wants to hear.

The Flawed Premise

Price = Client Budget $\neq$ Actual Effort

Truth-Based Estimate: Effort $\rightarrow$ Cost $\rightarrow$ Price

Best Offer Trap: Price $\rightarrow$ Compress Estimate $\rightarrow$ Hide Truth

A Commercial "Advantage" Only



Sales Tactic

It ensures the contract is won. The client sees a low price and feels good. It functions entirely as a sales tool, not an engineering method.



Short-Term Win

Initially, everyone appears happy. The deal is secured, the quota is met, and the project kicks off with false optimism.



Long-Term Loss

Scope creeps rapidly. Quality collapses due to rushed testing. Budgets overrun, and the client relationship is ultimately destroyed.

Inevitable Collapse

Structural Reality

Because costs do not reflect actual work, the probability that the client receives the functional software they desire is extremely low.

Features are delayed or cut. Testing is minimized, leading to explosive bug rates and a maintenance nightmare.

"Winning" the contract equals inheriting a toxic project.





If you win a contract by hiding the truth to match what the customer wants to pay, you mathematically guarantee an unviable asset.



THE MARKET OFFER PARADOX

Amplified Danger in Software Engineering



Hard to specify upfront

Software is notoriously difficult to fully define before work begins. "Best Offer" removes the vital buffer needed for discovery and iteration.



Easy to underestimate

Without rigorous breakdown, complex integrations and edge cases are missed. Artificial price compression guarantees these will break the project later.



Cheap to start, expensive to fix

Skipping foundational architecture and testing to meet a fake budget results in fragile, incomplete systems that are economically devastating to rescue.

The Engineering Antidote

100%

Mathematical Certainty

Prioritize Truth Over Sales

To cure systemic risks, we must enforce mathematical certainty over commercial compromise.

We must shift the mindset from *"What can we charge to win?"* to *"What does the work actually require?"*

Key Principle: Estimate from work, not from budget.

Work Breakdown Structure (WBS)

The primary antidote to the Best Offer trap is decomposing the project into granular, verifiable sub-units.

- Forces rigorous mapping of specification, design, implementation, testing, and maintenance directly into measurable tasks.
- Eliminates "gut feel" estimation and the temptation to alter numbers to fit external pressures.
- Produces empirical data to establish real cost, timeline, and risk profiles.

A clean 3D visualization of a large glowing cube breaking down into smaller cubes. The image shows a large, translucent, glowing blue cube in the center. It is surrounded by many smaller, similar glowing blue cubes of varying sizes, some of which are positioned as if they are falling away from or breaking apart from the main cube. The background is a dark, gradient blue, and the overall effect is one of digital disassembly or fragmentation.

WBS Hierarchy Breakdown

PROJECT PHASE	CONCRETE TASKS (LEAF NODES)	MEASURABLE EFFORT
Specification	Requirement interviews, Use case modeling, API contracts	Measured in Hours/Days
Design	Architecture decisions, Data modeling, Component diagrams	Measured in Hours/Days
Implementation	Module A logic, Module B logic, Third-party Integrations	Measured in Hours/Days
Testing & QA	Unit tests, Integration testing pipelines, QA cycles	Measured in Hours/Days
Maintenance	Bug fixing, Server monitoring, Minor enhancements	Measured in Hours/Days

Benefits of WBS for Teams

Empirical Authority

WBS equips you with objective data to say "no" to toxic, underfunded engagements.

It provides the mathematical backing to negotiate realistic budgets and justify cutting scope rather than silently cutting code quality.

Transparency & Predictability

Dramatically reduces hidden risks and surprise budget overruns.

By mapping out the exact reality of the work, it eliminates internal team blame cultures and builds profound trust with the client.

From WBS to "No" Power



Data-Driven Leverage

Instead of vague pushback, you present a mathematical truth: *"This specific scope = X hours of effort = Y total cost."*



Client Options

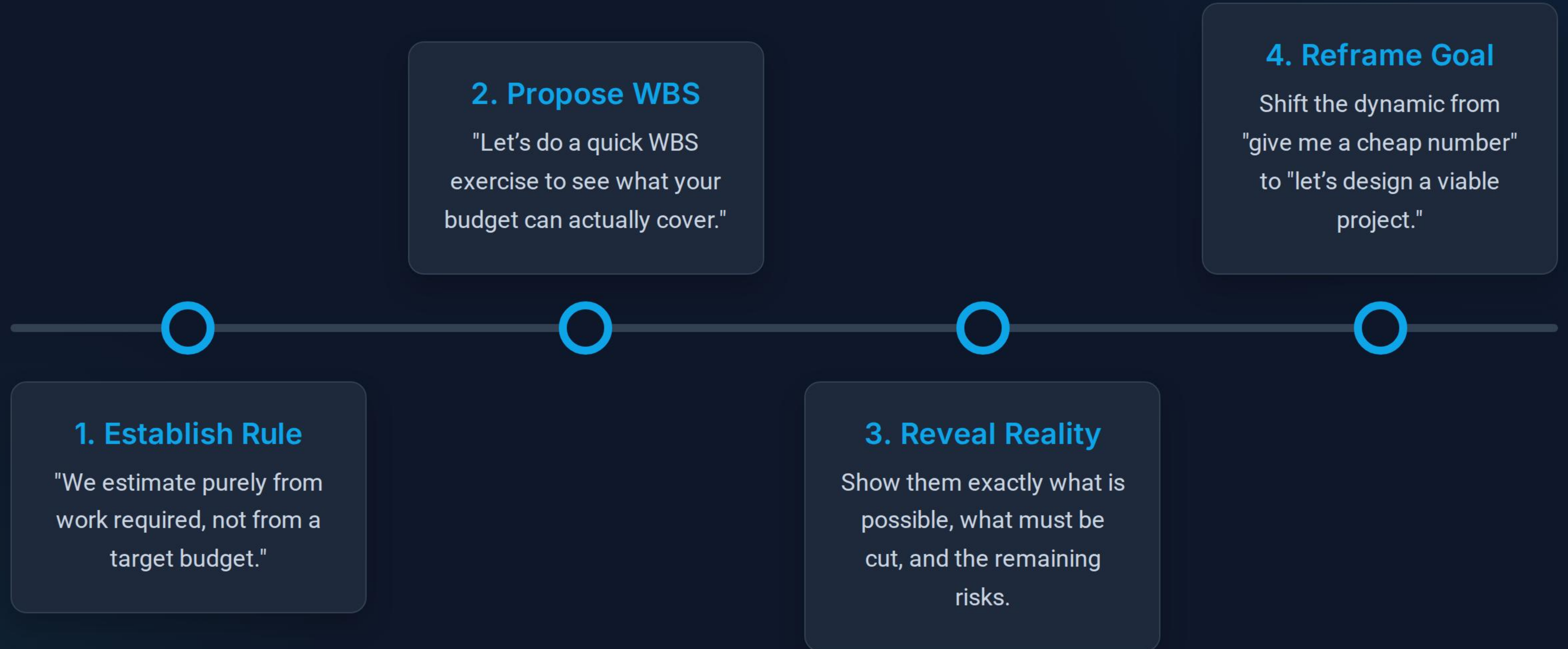
You return the power to the client with viable choices: Increase the budget, reduce the project scope, or extend the delivery timeline.



Professional "No"

It transforms a refusal from "we don't want to do it" into "the required work fundamentally does not fit within that budget constraint."

Responding to "Best Offer" Requests



Accept vs. Reject Matrix

Default to Reject When:

- The scope is unclear or highly volatile.
- The budget is demonstrably too low for core value.
- The client refuses transparency or collaboration.
- There is zero room for testing or iteration.

Only Consider (Rarely) When:

- The scope is tiny and rigidly defined.
- The budget actually matches your WBS estimate.
- The client understands the strict trade-offs.
- You are willing to lose money on a strategic pilot.

Don't Build Unviable Assets.

Stop using "Best Offer" as a valid estimation method.
Mandate WBS to ensure viability over contract signing.

Winning the contract is not the goal. Delivering value is.

Image Sources



<https://images.squarespace-cdn.com/content/v1/53daa85fe4b09a252f31a1bb/1774456894745-IBQBU140R1W6FQ3D4JKU/Paper+646.jpg?format=2500w>

Source: www.centralfine.com



https://cyberraiden.wordpress.com/wp-content/uploads/2025/08/sapphire-crystal-elegance_simple_compose_01k2z86z6y.jpg

Source: cyberraiden.wordpress.com



https://images.stockcake.com/public/0/9/9/0998bc6a-da63-4a13-b338-7e9e24ea4b27_large/digital-data-ecosystem-stockcake.jpg

Source: stockcake.com